TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

A data-forward analysis for engineering leads and technology strategists

Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon + 20+ sites

Ratings from skilled engineers, courses, vendors

Python leads at 21.25% — more than double second-place C — but posts the largest YoY decline among the top 5

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank	2025	Language	Rating	YoY Change	Visual
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%	
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%	
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%	
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%	
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%	
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%	
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%	
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%	
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%	
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%	
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%	
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%	
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%	
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%	
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%	
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%	
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%	
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%	
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%	
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%	

Insight: Top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) hold 48.97% of total TIOBE ratings

Legacy languages (Perl, R) show surprising resilience while Go suffers the sharpest decline of any top-20 language

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Biggest Gainers

Perl	24 ▲ 11	+1.05%	Largest gain in top 20
R	16 ▲ 9	+0.94%	Data science resurgence
Swift	26 ▲ 20	+0.44%	Re-entered top 20
Assembly	17 ▲ 17	+0.42%	Held rank, gained share
MATLAB	15 ▲ 15	+0.31%	Scientific computing steady
Ada	18 ▲ 19	+0.25%	Defense/aerospace steady
Rust	14 ▲ 14	+0.09%	Systems programming growth

Biggest Losers

Go	7 ▼ 16	-1.49%	Largest absolute drop in top 20
C++	2 ▼ 3	-2.90%	Biggest percentage drop
Java	3 ▼ 4	-2.37%	Continued long-term decline
Python	1 ▼ 1	-2.59%	Largest decline among top 5
PHP	13 ▼ 18	-0.25%	Web backend erosion
Fortran	11 ▼ 13	-0.25%	Scientific niche stable
Visual Basic	9 ▼ 7	-0.02%	Minor slip, held top 10

C is the only language to remain in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	–	–
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	–	–
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11		–	–
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	–	–
Go	10	11	60	16		–	–	–	–
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python's Meteoric Rise

From unranked before 1991 to #8 in 2006, surged to #1 after 2018. Peaked above 25%.

C's Unmatched Resilience

Only language in top 2 across all nine measurement points. Periodic surges in 2015 & 2026.

Java's Long Decline

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+. Steadily fell to under 8% by 2026. Dropped from #1 to #4.

Legacy Language Arcs

Lisp: #2 (1986) → #26 (2026).
Ada: #3 (1986) → #14 (2026).
JavaScript: never exceeded ~5%.

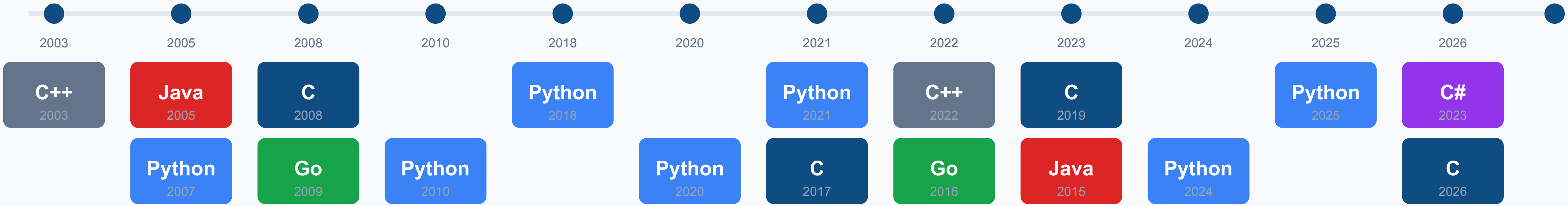
2002–2026 Trend Summary

Python surged from ~8th in 2006 to #1 after 2018, peaking above 25% before settling at 21.25%.
C held top-2 for 24 years with periodic surges. Java dominated 2005–2018 then steadily declined.
JavaScript plateaued around 3–5% despite web dominance — TIOBE measures discussion, not code volume.

Source: TIOBE historical trend chart (2002–2026)

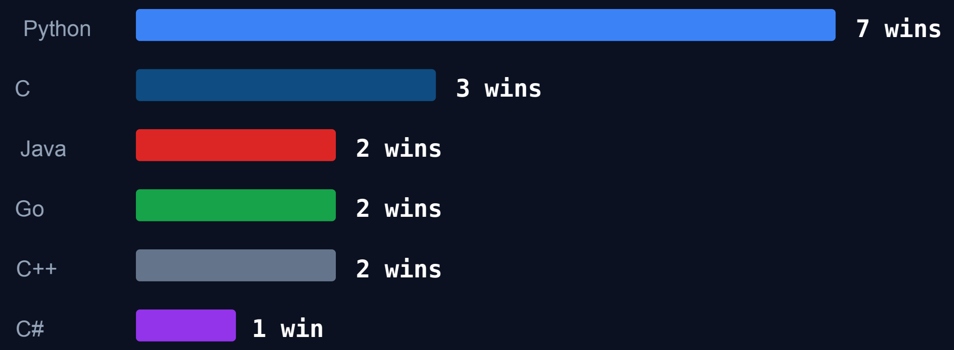
Python is the only language to win 7 times, making it the most decorated language in TIOBE history

Python Tops the TIOBE Hall of Fame with 7 Wins, Followed by C with 3



Legend: Python (7 wins) C (3 wins) Java (2 wins) Go (2 wins) C++ (2 wins) C# (1 win)

Language of the Year — Win Count Summary



Key Insights

- Python won 7 of 24 years (29%) — unprecedented dominance
- C won 3 times: 2008, 2017, 2019 — periodic resurgence
- Java won 2 times: 2005, 2015 — during its peak dominance
- Go won 2 times: 2009, 2016 — early growth years
- C# won 1 time: 2023 — Microsoft's open-source pivot

Note: "Language of the Year" = highest YoY rise in rating

TIOBE measures search-engine discussion volume, not code volume — use it as a sentiment signal, not a usage metric

What the TIOBE Index Means for Your Technology Strategy

Talent & Hiring

Python's 21.25% share

Despite its YoY decline, Python remains the most discussed language. Expect continued talent availability but also increased competition for senior Python engineers.

R's resurgence (+0.94%)

Data science roles may see renewed R demand alongside Python. Don't write off R for statistical-heavy positions.

Go's decline (-1.49%)

Despite Go's popularity in cloud-native infrastructure, its TIOBE discussion share dropped. Hiring may become easier as hype normalizes.

ACTION:
Prioritize Python/R pipelines; watch Go hiring costs fall.

Tech Stack Decisions

C's surge to #2 (+2.02%)

C's resurgence signals renewed interest in systems-level programming. Embedded, IoT, and performance-critical applications may benefit from C expertise investment.

Rust steady at #14 (+0.09%)

Rust continues slow but steady growth. For memory-safe systems, Rust is the strategic long-term bet over C++.

C++ decline (-2.90%)

C++ saw the largest percentage drop. Consider migration paths for new projects: Rust for systems, Go for services.

ACTION:
Invest in C for systems; pilot Rust for new codebases.

Strategic Context

Python's YoY decline (-2.59%)

Even dominant languages face saturation. Python's decline from peak suggests market maturation, not collapse. Plan for polyglot environments.

Java's long-term erosion

Java fell from #1 to #4 over 15 years. Enterprises should evaluate modernization paths without disruption: Kotlin, Go, or cloud-native alternatives.

TIOBE as sentiment signal

TIOBE measures search-engine discussion volume, not actual code volume. Use it to gauge community momentum and talent market trends.

ACTION:
Use TIOBE as one input; validate with GitHub/Stack Overflow data.